

THE TURNING POINT

SEPTEMBER 1967–DECEMBER 1968

In the fall of 1967, North Vietnam and the Viet Cong began to prepare for an offensive they hoped would win the war. After diversionary attacks on American bases in border areas, they delivered the main thrust of their offensive during the Tet (New Year) holiday in early 1968. The Viet Cong fought for control of towns and cities across South Vietnam, while the North Vietnamese Army seized the city of Hue. In spite of the scale of the attack, the Tet Offensive was a military failure for the communists, and Viet Cong forces were weakened substantially by the campaign. US and South Vietnamese (ARVN) troops retook urban areas, and US Marines successfully defeated a siege of their base at Khe Sanh. Later in 1968, a second phase of the Tet Offensive, “Mini Tet,” also failed to win significant military gains for the North Vietnamese and Viet Cong.